all the participants developed stakes in India's success. Whether it was the manner in which diplomacy was conducted, culture and heritage projected or popular participation was encouraged, the G20 presidency was very much an exercise in the India way.

As a practitioner long associated with our diplomacy, there are two responsibilities that I seek to discharge through this book. One is to share the thinking of a rising power with a world that has become increasingly aware of that happening. The other is to communicate the necessity of accurately understanding global developments to our own people. Only then can our nation fully appreciate the opportunities and challenges that lie before it. These twin exercises are, however, united in their cultural underpinnings. After all, this foundation influences our approach to the world as a family, as it does the pluralistic and consultative nature of our society. They shape our political ethos too, just as they promote our democratic choices. The manner in which debates are conducted, decisions reached and positions articulated, all have their own cultural signature. But above all, they bring out the values and ethics that are at the core of our collective personality.

Sagas of nations, while developed to grip the imagination of their peoples, are a distillate of wisdom, beliefs and habits. For those whose cultures and traditions came under pressure in difficult periods of history, they are also a crucial motivator. The really great tales offer insights that help to spread influence beyond boundaries and to help propagate messages. It is, therefore, tempting to draw from them lessons that can be applied to the contemporary world. Especially in times of turbulence, episodes and outcomes can provide guidance, offer parallels and strengthen self-belief. Indeed, because epics serve as an instructive way to view the happenings of any period, they remain eternally relevant.

Of India's two major epics, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, it is the latter that is normally associated with statecraft and diplomacy. There are many reasons for this perception, among them the storyline itself. But even that arises from the fact that these two sagas are set in different eras, each with their own behavioural expectations. The Ramayana, which is the earlier one, has purity of thought and nobility of conduct as its central message. In contrast, the Mahabharata is much more a chronicle of human frailty and pursuance of ambition. In today's terminology, we would see one as a quest for the observance of rules and norms, while assessing the other